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Presidential Telephone Calls - Memorandum of Conversations 8/1/89 - 10/23/89

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THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTONMEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telephone Call to Chancellor Helmut Kohl of
West Germany (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Helmut Kohl, Chancellor
Notetaker: Robert Hutchings

DATE, TIME August 3, 1989, 2:01 - 2:10 pm EDT
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

The President initiated the call and inquired about Chancellor Kohl's vacation. (U)

Chancellor Kohl replied that it was too cool in the Austrian Alps but that he had been swimming, hiking and thinking. He had been thinking in particular of the President and sympathizing with what must be a terrible burden. This type of terrorism [in Lebanon] is one of the worst scourges mankind has experienced. The Chancellor said that he had seen on television pictures of the kidnapped Americans, which brought to mind the kidnapping and murder of his friend Hans Martin Schleier. Schleier had conveyed a message via television to the Chancellor during that period, so the Chancellor knew what must be going on in the President's mind now. (U)

The President expressed his very great thanks and said he wanted to bring the Chancellor up to date on the situation. The tape of Cicippio is of particular concern. In fifty-five minutes the deadline will arrive for his death, so the situation is very similar to the message the Chancellor had mentioned. The President recalled an earlier conversation in which the Chancellor had expressed his great affection for Schleier and said the U.S. is going through the same anguish now. (U)

Chancellor Kohl then mentioned the Hamadei case and assured the President that he would not give in. The Chancellor would stick to what he had told the President before. (U)

The President said there was a small ray of hope. The U.S. had some information that Iran is trying to be helpful. (U)

Chancellor Kohl said that would be very good and the President should seize the opportunity. (U)

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The President said that he is not putting too much hope on it, but there have been tidbits of information that suggest the possibility is worth exploring. The President added that if another American is murdered, his hands would be tied in many ways. He could not sit idly by. The U.S. would have to take some kind of action. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl said he could understand that very well. (Ø)

The President said he had been making a lot of telephone calls to those who may have some influence with the kidnappers, or with Iran or Lebanon. He hope those with influence would help where they can. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl said that he would help in any way possible. He would be at any time if the President wanted to call on him. (U)

The President concluded by noting that after the Chancellor's vacation he would be calling again to discuss problems with other countries in the region. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl said he would welcome that and repeated his offer to help in any way. He added that an important principle in his life was the help friends in any way possible. (U)